The Epistemology of Coexistence

Author: AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.org — a group of people studying Madhyasth Darshan philosophy. Source repository: raghavamohan/AnalyticMadhyasthDarshan.

Edited on: July 17, 2026, 2:19 PM IST

The question: What is knowledge, who is the knower, and what is it that one can know? How are these concepts grounded in experience, and how does the Co-existentialism of Shri A. Nagraj compare with Advaita Vedanta, modern Western philosophy, and the natural sciences?

This study examines knowledge, the knower, and the knowable in **Madhyasth Darshan** (Co-existentialism), as presented by **Shri A. Nagraj**, and compares its answers with **Advaita Vedanta** and **modern science and philosophy**.

The Ontology of Coexistence supplies the ontological setting: Omnipresence, saturated units, the four orders, constitutional completeness, and the active structure of *jeevan*. The present study asks the specifically epistemological questions developed in *Manav Karm Darshan*: what knowledge is, what makes *jeevan* the knower, how coexistence becomes the known, and why understanding must become evident in action, relationship, evaluation, and humane tradition. Coexistence From First Principles is used as an interpretive audit of these connections, not as a primary source and not as a source of notation for this paper.

Standpoint and scope

These studies are written from the standpoint of a **scientist and technologist** — someone trained to graduate-level **physics and mathematics**, at home with contemporary cosmology, quantum theory, conservation laws, and the logic of formal models.

From that background, a familiar picture of nature is hard to avoid: **consciousness appears as something the brain does** — an epiphenomenon, functional outcome, or emergent property of particular configurations of very large numbers of physical particles. Modern physics and cognitive science are powerful on mechanism, prediction, and public evidence; yet the hard problem of consciousness, the status of the self, and the reality of value remain fiercely contested. The standpoint taken here does not treat those gaps as settled in favour of matter-only reductionism.

The work begins where that scientific picture leaves open questions — and asks whether Madhyasth Darshan offers a coherent alternative worth examining seriously. This paper reads the primary texts carefully, states what follows from the darshan itself, and compares it in parallel with what we know from **physics and the natural sciences**, **Advaita Vedanta**, and **modern Western philosophy** (especially epistemology and philosophy of mind). Physics and mathematics are **one leg** of that comparison, not the only one. The aim is rigorous comparative understanding — testing definitions, internal consistency, and fit with public knowledge — not persuasion or devotional endorsement.

These topical studies state the philosophy in clear, checkable prose first. A separate formal mathematical treatment may follow once the definitions and relations are stable across the studies; this paper does not assume or require that treatment.

1. The Madhyasth Darshan Answer

Madhyasth Darshan holds that knowledge is realised understanding of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct; that the knower is the sentient *jeevan* whose knowing becomes evident through the human joint form; and that the known is coexistence understood and made meaningful through awakened living. Knowledge is therefore neither information alone nor a private conviction. It begins from an ontological claim about saturated existence, develops through the activities of *jeevan*, and is tested through behaviour, work, evaluation, transmission, and participation in orderliness.

1.1 Pervasive knowledge and the activity of knowing

The source texts use *gyan* at several connected levels, while locating the activity of knowing in *jeevan*. The distinctions made here are analytical aids drawn from those usages, not a canonical fourfold taxonomy.

At the ontological level, insentient and sentient nature saturated in Omnipresence is named **Realisation Knowledge** (*anubhav jnan*). Every unit has form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma*, and has inherent orderliness while participating in overall orderliness (MVD, p. 11). This does not mean that every unit thinks. It names saturated coexistence as the reality available for understanding.

The texts also call the omnipresent ground itself Knowledge or Space:

> **"Knowledge itself is the omnipresent Omnipotence. This itself is referred to as Space."**
> *— MVD, p. 35*

Omnipresence does not think: it is actionless, non-transforming, and not a unit. Calling it Knowledge identifies the all-pervasive ground in which reality is orderly and intelligible; it does not make Omnipresence a subject that perceives or decides. The active knower is *jeevan* , and what it knows is coexistence rather than Space in isolation. SB lists Uniform Energy, Space, Knowledge, Consciousness, Omnipresence, Eternity, God, and Absolute Energy as English names for the same *satta* (SB, p. 48). These translations create a genuine interpretive tension, but they do not turn *satta* into a universal mind.

Human knowledge is the realisation of coexistence and its expression as knowledge, wisdom, and science. MVD distinguishes the omnipresence of knowledge from its **unfolding** (*gyan udghatan*): knowledge remains present everywhere, while its unfolding occurs through awakened humans (MVD, pp. 115–116), and only through the sentient aspect or thought (MVD, p. 289). Realisation in coexistence is complete knowledge; knowledge-unfolding is the awakened knower's expression of that realisation. The Ontology of Coexistence §§1.1–1.2 and 1.13 develop the ontological background; the distinction needed here is simply that pervasive *gyan* is not itself a perceiving agent.

1.2 Knowledge, knower, and known

Manav Karm Darshan gives the triad its most direct treatment. Knowledge has three inseparable contents: the holistic view of existence as coexistence, knowledge of *jeevan*, and knowledge of humane conduct (KD §3.17, pp. 145–150; SB, p. 116). MVD adds that realisation itself is knowledge. Complete knowing therefore joins what exists, who understands it, and how that understanding is lived.

The **knower** is *jeevan*. The source also calls the human being the knower because human evidence requires the joint form of *jeevan* and body. These are two levels of one account, not rival answers. *Jeevan* is the sentient bearer of realisation, enlightenment, contemplation, deliberation, and selection. The human being is the embodied participant who speaks, works, behaves, evaluates, teaches, and joins orderliness. MVD accordingly says that knowledge becomes evident in human tradition through the knower together with the object of knowledge, and that all humans are capable of becoming knowers (MVD, p. 115).

The **known** also has two connected senses in KD. The introductory *Alternative* names existence as coexistence as the object to be known, while KD §3.17 says that the known becomes meaningful when awakening evidences human aspiration and *jeevan* aspiration through undivided society and universal orderliness. Coexistence is what is known; resolved, prosperous, fearless, and coexistential living is the evidence that the known has become meaningful. This avoids reducing the known either to an external object or to a social outcome alone.

1.3 Seeing, attention, action, and seeking

KD §3.17 places the knowledge triad among several related structures. Its technical trio is *drish–drishya–darshan*: *drish* is assigned to *jeevan* as the subject or capacity of seeing, *drishya* to existence as coexistence as the seen, and *darshan* to the meaningful exposition of existence. This use of *drish* should not be confused with treating it merely as a separate act of seeing. MVD states a related structure from the side of perspective: the perceiver uses *drishti* to see the *drishya*, and the accomplishment of that process as *darshan* is understanding or knowledge (MVD, p. 84). *Drishti* is therefore the perspective exercised, while *drishta* names the realised status of the seer; neither is interchangeable with every term in KD's trio.

MVD says that relativity (*sapekshata*) arises from distinctions among perspective, the observed, and worldview (MVD, p. 210). The source does not thereby make coexistence ontologically relative. It locates relativity in differentiated seeing: a sentient unit can view and evaluate through pleasure, health, and profit or through justice, *dharma*, and truth. The world remains real while human perspective may be incomplete or deluded.

KD's attention triad identifies awakening as the object of attention and the human being as the attender. Its aim–seeker–means triad names awakening or seer-status as the aim, the human being as seeker, and the joint resources of body and *jeevan* as means. The chapter later widens those means to imagination, freedom of action, and evidence-bearing tradition. Its cause–doer–effect formulations similarly operate at more than one level: coexistence is the ever-present ground, the human being acts, and awakened human and social orderliness are the effects made evident. These related triads prevent epistemology from becoming detached spectatorship. Knowing includes attention, purpose, embodied means, action, and consequence.

1.4 *Jeevan* as the active knower

The knower is not an actionless witness. *Jeevan* is a constitutionally complete sentient unit whose ten coordinated activities are distributed across *atma*, *buddhi*, *chitta*, *vritti*, and *mun*. JV names realisation and authenticity in *atma*; enlightenment and resolve in *buddhi*; contemplation and visualisation in *chitta*; deliberation and analysis in *vritti*; and taste and selection in *mun* (JV, pp. 92–93). The working KD translation sometimes renders the receptive activity of *chitta* as direct recognition (*sakshatkar*); the common point is meaning-bearing recognition rather than sensation alone.

These activities have two directions. **Reflection** is the knowing direction in which sensation, behaviour, thought, desire, and resolve are examined until enlightenment and realisation become possible. **Projection** is the evidencing direction in which realisation and resolve take form as visualisation, analysis, selection, bodily action, work, behaviour, and communication (KD §§3.12, 3.16–3.17). Knowing and doing are thus recurrent aspects of one active *jeevan*, not independent faculties that meet only after a conclusion has been reached.

The human body is the necessary medium for this evidence. The brain (*medhas*) receives and processes signals associated with *jeevan*'s hopes, thoughts, desires, resolves, and authenticity (MVD, pp. 83–84). MVD separately states that waves triggered on the brain through the cognitive organs participate in knowledge-unfolding (MVD, p. 200). These are textual claims about the joint form; they do not yet provide a modern neurophysical account of how *jeevan* and neural activity interact.

In delusion, only four and a half of the ten activities become effective: selection and taste, analysis, visualisation, and a restricted part of deliberation governed by pleasure, health, and profit (JV, pp. 73, 92–93; KD §3.17, p. 147). The remaining activities do not become evident because the body is taken to be the self. The epistemic failure is therefore not mere absence of information. It is incomplete functioning of the knower's own capacities, producing self-contradiction between the aspiration for happiness and conduct governed principally by sensation.

The two directions consequently form a different circuit in delusion and awakening. In delusion, reflection does not reach effective enlightenment and realisation, so projection remains organised by sensory criteria and the partial activities just named. In awakening, reflection reaches *buddhi* and *atma*; realisation and resolve then project through *chitta*, *vritti*, and *mun* as coherent visualisation, analysis, selection, and embodied conduct. Madhyasth Darshan thus treats self-contradiction as a break among aspiration, understanding, and action, not simply as a mistaken proposition.

1.5 Knowing, believing, recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating

JV defines knowledge in the human process as knowing together with believing:

> **"What is knowledge? Knowing and believing constitute knowledge."**
> *— JV, p. 165*

MVD compresses the discipline as "Believe what is known; know what is believed" (MVD, p. 12). Believing here is not assent without grounds. It is acceptance of what has been understood as relevant to one's own activity. Knowing without acceptance remains ineffectual; acceptance without knowing is inherited belief and a basis of delusion.

Knowing and believing must continue into recognising relationships and fulfilling their values. Fulfilment depends on capacity, ability, and receptivity (*kshamata*, *yogyata*, *patrata*), so correct conception does not guarantee completed conduct. At the knowledge order, evaluation then asks whether the relationship and value have actually been fulfilled. Recognition, fulfilment, evaluation, and mutual satisfaction together constitute justice (MVD, p. 311; JV, p. 55). Trust is not a substitute for that process but the value evidenced when a relationship's expectation is fulfilled.

The first three orders—the material, biological or *prana*, and animal orders—recognise and fulfil through structural, seed, or species conformance; their orderliness does not depend on reflective choice. Human imagination and freedom of action loosen that automatic fit. The knowledge order must therefore add knowing and believing before action and explicit evaluation after it. A person may know without accepting, accept without recognising a present relationship, recognise without fulfilling it, or act without evaluating the result. Humane conduct is not an ethical supplement to this epistemology: it is what the complete sequence looks like in relationship. CFP §4.13 usefully exposes these failure points, but the present account needs no formal notation: awakening is increasing coherence across the whole sequence, not success in only one of its activities.

Sensitivity and cognisance name the two sides of embodied engagement. Sensitivity responds through the body and senses; cognisance understands relationship, value, and orderliness through *jeevan*. The source calls for their balance, not the elimination of sensitivity:

> **"...the recognising and fulfilling of the insentient and the sentient world is through the balance of cognisance and sensitivity."**
> *— SB, p. 64*

1.6 Completeness and the seer–doer–enjoyer

Constitutional completeness establishes *jeevan* as a sentient unit; activity completeness and conduct completeness concern its awakening. Activity completeness is the restfulness of internal effort when understanding is no longer divided by delusion. Conduct completeness is the destination of outward motion when that understanding becomes stable in work, behaviour, relationship, and universal orderliness (The Ontology of Coexistence §§1.6.2–1.6.3).

KD §3.18 connects these transitions with the seer, doer, and enjoyer. Here *seer* does not denote *drish*, the epistemic subject or capacity in the seeing triad of §1.3. It denotes awakened *drishta-pad*: established seer-status. Physicochemical units are already self-motivated doers in the sense of effort, motion, and result, and their actual results supply the basis for enjoyer-status. In animal life and deluded human life, doing and undergoing results continue without the seer-status of realised understanding. The awakened human adds this seer-status: understanding becomes established as the knower together with knowledge, while embodied activity evidences the doer and experienced result the enjoyer. Mutual satisfaction (§1.5) is one humane form of result under awakening, not the definition of enjoyer-status itself. Madhyasth Darshan's knower is therefore active without being reducible to action alone.

The four *jeevan* values name harmonies among the faculties: happiness between *mun* and *vritti*, peace between *vritti* and *chitta*, contentment between *chitta* and *buddhi*, and bliss between *buddhi* and *atma* (JV, p. 138). They are not quantities on one scale; outward success cannot compensate for unresolved understanding, and private calm cannot substitute for failed relationships. The *jeevan* aspiration of happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss becomes meaningful together with the human aspiration of resolution in the person, prosperity in the family, fearlessness in society, and coexistence in universal orderliness (KD §3.17, p. 150; JV, pp. 61, 165).

1.7 Karma, result, and evidence

Manav Karm Darshan places action inside epistemology. Activity together with aspiration is karma, and every karma has result. Intentional action contains a doer, cause, objective, result, and effect; desire, action, and result must therefore be examined together rather than treating intention as sufficient (KD Ch. 1). Capacity, bodily conditions, other people, material means, and environment all mediate the result.

Result returns to the knower through evaluation. It may confirm that a relationship and purpose were understood, or expose over-evaluation, under-evaluation, and mis-evaluation. Repeated action and evaluation shape *sanskar*, which conditions later projection without making human conduct constitutionally fixed. This is the prose form of the recurrent karma structure clarified in CFP §4.14: understanding becomes answerable to consequence, and consequence becomes material for corrected understanding.

The texts distinguish deluded and awakened action sharply. The deluded human is free while acting but dependent while undergoing the result; the awakened human is free both while acting and while undergoing it. In deluded tradition, understanding is sought after doing; in awakened tradition, action follows understanding (MVD, *Verity*, p. 14; KD Ch. 1). The claim is not that awakened action controls every external event. It is that action is chosen with understanding of relationship, purpose, and result, so its consequences do not contradict the knower's accepted aim.

MVD states the evidence chain directly:

> **"Realisation – Behaviour – Experiment"**
> *— MVD, p. 12*
>
> **"Realisation itself is the ultimate evidence, Evidence itself is the understanding or knowledge, Understanding itself is manifest, The manifest itself is resolution, work and behaviour, Work and behaviour itself is evidence, Evidence itself is awakened tradition, Awakened tradition itself is coexistence."**
> *— MVD, p. 12*

Realisation is the first term, behaviour the middle term, and experiment the practical extension in which understanding faces material and social result. Experiment here includes lived and productive participation, not only controlled laboratory testing. It does not follow that successful conduct proves every ontological assertion by scientific standards. Madhyasth Darshan proposes a broader evidence regime in which first-person realisation, second-person conveyance, and publicly observable work, behaviour, and social outcomes must cohere.

This use of *pramana* shifts the centre of gravity from the inputs by which a cognition arises to the evidence by which realised understanding is confirmed. Perception, inference, and testimony retain roles in study (§1.8), but a verbal claim or private contemplative state does not complete the test. In Madhyasth Darshan, *pramana* culminates when realisation becomes evident through human behaviour, work, experiment, evaluation, conveyance, and an awakened tradition. This differs from the classical use of *pramana* for an instrument or source of valid cognition, examined in §2.6.

JV locates realisation and authenticity (*pramanikta*) as activities of *atma* (JV, p. 92). Authenticity is therefore not identical to outward conduct. It is the knower's realisation-bearing capacity to evidence what is understood; conduct, teaching, and tradition are its outward manifestations. A person may repeat correct words or conform legally without this inner and outer coherence.

1.8 Study, realisation, and transmission

Nagraj's account of discovery is epistemically important because it refuses to identify altered contemplative state with knowledge. In the autobiographical *Alternative* to KD, he reports that *samadhi* quieted expectation, thought, and desire but produced no event of the unknown becoming known. He attributes the claimed direct seeing of coexistence to *samyama* and presents the resulting darshan for study and verification (KD, *Alternative*, points 1, 5, and 11). This is first-person testimony about the origin of the system, not independent public confirmation of its ontology.

For later students, the texts describe study as oriented toward realisation from the beginning: "The study is in, by and for realisation in coexistence" (MVD, p. 35). Study includes language, definition, comparison, reflection, practice, work, and behaviour. KD §3.17 says the resulting line of evidence should be available for every person to take to heart, test within oneself, and assess across practice, study, work, and behavioural orderliness. The claim is thus universal accessibility through disciplined participation, not privileged revelation that must remain ineffable.

KD also recognises direct perception, inference, and testimony-activity rather than treating realisation as the only cognitive route. It relates direct perception to what can be brought into experiential proximity, inference to what is possible beyond present proximity, and testimony to what is established beyond that inferential reach (KD, pp. 20–21). Gross form and property, subtle property and essential nature, and causal essential nature and *dharma* require correspondingly developed capacities of attention and understanding. These categories do not reproduce Advaita's hierarchy of *pramanas*: they are nested within a method whose final criterion is coherent realisation and evidence, not scriptural testimony alone.

Transmission through an awakened human and humane tradition remains essential. JV states:

> **"The proof of our comprehension lies in our ability to convey it to others; this is the litmus test of our wisdom."**
> *— JV, p. 26*

Conveyance is more than verbal fluency. The learner must be able to understand, live, evaluate, and in turn make the understanding accessible without contradiction. *Sanskar* carries acceptances toward completeness and the knowledge, wisdom, and science needed for resolution; environment, study, endeavour, humaneness, and awakening support one another (MVD, pp. 90, 290).

MVD Ch. 17 describes two broad paths out of intellectual mystery: exploration, and following through emulation and study in awakened tradition. Reflection is supported by universal orderliness, social conduct, study and *sanskar*, and inward regulation. MVD further requires delusion-less knowledge, just behaviour, resolved thought, and disciplined relation to a realised teacher for realisation in knowledge (MVD, pp. 273–285, 317). These requirements should be stated as the darshan's method and also examined critically: guidance may enable transmission, but deference cannot by itself establish the truth of what is taught.

1.9 Delusion, false learning, and mystery

The root of delusion (*bhram*) is identifying *jeevan* with the body (JV, p. 93). Once the body is treated as the self, sensitivity supplies the governing reference points and believing separates from knowing. The resulting four-and-a-half-activity condition is an internal account of why sophisticated thought can coexist with unresolved desire, conflict, and mis-evaluation.

False learning is a related but distinct failure. MVD defines it as lack of awakening to understand a thing's form, properties, essential nature, and *dharma* as they are (MVD, p. 184), and elsewhere associates it with doubt, over-evaluation, under-evaluation, and mis-evaluation (MVD, pp. 263–264). One may possess information, arguments, or institutional authority while failing to recognise the object or relationship adequately.

MVD calls incompleteness in understanding state and activity "mystery" and says holistic view removes it (MVD, p. 209). Ch. 17 locates intellectual mystery in failed alignment among *mun*, *vritti*, *chitta*, *buddhi*, and *atma*: reflection does not reach realisation, or realisation does not project as evidence. Delusion-less knowledge is knowing, understanding, and imparting realities as they are (MVD, p. 317).

This is a strong commitment to structural knowability and communicability. It should not be inflated into the claim that an awakened person possesses every contingent fact or every future scientific result. The texts claim that coexistence, its orders, *jeevan*, and humane conduct can be known without a remainder of ontological mystery. Whether holistic certitude can be distinguished from overconfidence remains an open epistemological problem (§7.1).

1.10 The scope of the known

The object of knowledge is existence as coexistence: Omnipresence and real units with form, properties, essential nature, *dharma*, relationships, and participation in orderliness. It includes the material, biological, animal, and knowledge orders; effort, motion, result, development, and awakening; values and relationships; and humane conduct. KD accordingly distinguishes physical, intellectual, and spiritual or coexistential knowledge as manifested through skill, proficiency, and scholarliness (KD, pp. 3–4). Measuring external properties is therefore one part of knowing, not its completion.

The known becomes meaningful when these contents guide relationship and participation. KD §3.17 links its evidence to responsibilities and duties in lived relationships, to work and behavioural orderliness, and finally to the human and *jeevan* aspirations. This is why humane conduct is part of knowledge rather than a moral appendix added after metaphysics.

The world known in this way is real and perpetual:

> **"Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual."**
> *— MVD, "Fundamental Concepts," point 8 ("Reality"), p. 13*

Awakening does not erase the knower–known distinction by absorbing both into one subject. At realisation, knowledge, knower, and known become coherent within coexistence: existence remains the known, *jeevan* remains the knower, and knowledge is the realised relation evidenced as wisdom, science, and humane conduct (The Ontology of Coexistence §1.13).

1.11 Knower persistence and its epistemic standing

Madhyasth Darshan treats *jeevan* as constitutionally complete and therefore persistent across bodily birth and death:

> **"Jeevan continues to exist even after death as it does while driving a body."**
> *— JV, p. 20*

This claim is part of the ontology of the knower, but it is not established merely by the epistemic criterion of conduct-evidence. The texts infer persistence from the indestructibility of the constitutionally complete sentient unit and the conservation of what exists. Modern physics conserves quantities such as energy and charge, not automatically the identity of every structured entity. Constitutional completeness must therefore do independent metaphysical work.

Public evaluation would require operational criteria for constitutional completeness, reproducible evidence distinguishing *jeevan*-mediated from brain-only activity, and independent evidence of post-death continuity. Until such evidence exists, *jeevan* persistence remains a primary commitment of Madhyasth Darshan rather than an established result of contemporary science (The Ontology of Coexistence §§1.14 and 6.2.3).

2. The Advaita Vedanta Answer

Advaita Vedanta gives two answers to the question of the knower, and comparison becomes distorted if they are collapsed. Within empirical life (*vyavahara*), an embodied person cognizes through perception, inference, testimony, and the other accepted means of knowledge. From the absolute standpoint (*paramartha*), the witnessing Self is not one individual knower among others: it is non-dual consciousness, identical with Brahman, in which the distinction between knower, known, and knowing does not finally apply. The world is consequently valid for empirical cognition while remaining *mithya*, dependent rather than independently absolute.

2.1 Empirical knower and witnessing consciousness

Classical Indian epistemology analyses a cognition through a subject or knower (*pramatr*), a means of knowledge (*pramana*), an object (*prameya*), and the resulting valid cognition (*prama*). Advaita accepts this structure at the empirical level. The embodied *jiva*, equipped with body, senses, and the internal organ (*antahkarana*), is the person who sees, infers, remembers, deliberates, and acts. *Ahamkara*, the appropriating "I"-notion, is one function in this empirical complex; it is not simply a synonym for the whole *jiva*.

Later Advaita manuals commonly describe cognition through a modification of the internal organ (*antahkarana-vritti*) that takes the form of an object and is illumined by consciousness reflected in the mind (*chidabhasa*). The actionless witness (*sakshin*) does not perform an epistemic operation alongside perception or inference. It is that by whose presence the changing cognitions of the empirical subject are manifest. The seer–seen discrimination makes this distinction vivid: whatever can itself be observed cannot be the final witness.

> **"The form1… is perceived and the eye… is its perceiver… It… is perceived and the mind… is its perceiver. The mind with… modifications is perceived and the Witness (the Self) is verily the perceiver… But… is not perceived…"**
> *— DDV, p. 15*

The physical body, senses, emotions, and thoughts are all available as objects of awareness; Advaita therefore denies that any one of them is the ultimate seer. Bhagavad Gita 13.1–3 distinguishes the body as "field" from its knower and then identifies the one knower in all fields. At the empirical level, however, different persons remain accountable agents and knowers. The text does not license replacing every ordinary act of knowing with an actionless transcendental observer.

The *Mandukya Upanishad* (MU, vv. 3–7) analyses waking, dream, and deep sleep before indicating *turiya*. Deep sleep is not simply a blank witnessed as another object: *prajna* is described as undifferentiated, a mass of consciousness and a causal condition in which distinct objects are not cognized, while ignorance remains. *Turiya* is neither an additional experiential state nor the deep-sleep condition; it is the non-dual Self that is not exhausted by any of the three.

The five-sheath analysis associated with the *Taittiriya Upanishad* (TU, 2.1–2.5), and developed explicitly as a method of discrimination in later works such as the *Vivekachudamani* (VC, vv. 154–212), similarly refuses to identify the Self with food-body, vitality, mind, intellect, or causal bliss. Madhyasth Darshan reuses some of the same *kosha* vocabulary but assigns it a different role: its layers are activities and powers of an enduring *jeevan* to be understood in awakened participation, not coverings whose discrimination culminates in the unreality of individual separateness (The Ontology of Coexistence §5.7.2).

2.2 Empirical knowledge and liberating knowledge

Advaita does not reduce every instance of knowledge to mystical realization. Perceptual and inferential cognitions can be valid within empirical life: a person may know a pot, a medical fact, or another person's testimony without thereby knowing Brahman. Liberating knowledge (*brahma-jnana*) is different in scope. It removes the basic superimposition by which the non-objectifiable Self is taken to be a limited body-mind and reveals the identity indicated by the Upanishadic great sayings.

> **"Brahman is truth, knowledge, infinite."**
> *— TU, 2.1.1*

The *Taittiriya* expression *satyam jnanam anantam brahma* describes Brahman as reality, consciousness or knowledge, and infinitude. It should not be presented as though the Upanishadic sentence were itself the later compact formula Sat-Chit-Ananda. Advaita receives that later formula as a convergent characterization: not three properties added to a substance, but indications of partless reality as existence, consciousness, and fullness. Consciousness is self-revealing (*svaprakasha*); it is not known by a second consciousness, which would generate an infinite regress.

> **"By that alone he comes to know his own Self as Existence-Knowledge-Bliss Absolute and becomes happy."**
> *— VC, v. 152*

Ordinary knowledge preserves the knower–means–known relation. Liberating knowledge removes the ignorance that made this relation appear finally independent. Brahman is consequently not a supreme object known by a surviving individual subject, nor an "absolute knower-known ground" in which both terms retain their ordinary meanings. At *paramartha*, the relational triad no longer applies.

2.3 Error, sublation, and levels of reality

Shankara opens the *Brahma Sutra Bhashya* by diagnosing mutual superimposition (*adhyasa*): the properties of body and mind are attributed to the Self, while consciousness and selfhood are attributed to the body-mind complex. Ordinary perceptual error, such as mistaking a rope for a snake, illustrates correction by sublation (*badha*): what appeared is cancelled by a cognition that discloses its substrate. Later Advaita develops this into the technical account of *mithya* as neither independently real nor sheer non-being.

The familiar three-level scheme is a useful later systematization rather than a single doctrine laid out as a table by Shankara. It distinguishes private or apparent error (*pratibhasika*), shared empirical order (*vyavaharika*), and the non-dual absolute (*paramarthika*).

Level	What is known?	Status of error
Apparent (*pratibhasika*)	Rope-snake, dream objects, private errors	Sublated by waking or correction
Empirical (*vyavahara*)	Bodies, minds, Ishvara, causes, duties, scriptures, science	Shared, law-governed; operationally valid; sublated only by *brahma-jnana*
Absolute (*paramartha*)	Brahman, not as an object opposed to a subject	Knower–known plurality is sublated

At *vyavahara*, the world is not unreal in the way a hallucination is. It is the common field in which evidence, error, causal order, duty, and instruction operate. Its dependence is disclosed only relative to Brahman. Madhyasth Darshan rejects this final sublation: error is removable misidentification within a fully real coexistence, not an epistemic condition whose removal cancels the ultimate independence of plurality (§1.9).

2.4 The nature of the knower

At *vyavahara*, the knower is the embodied *jiva*: the Self apparently delimited by body, senses, internal organ, ignorance, and agency. This empirical subject is neither identical with *ahamkara* alone nor dismissed as a hallucination. It is the bearer of responsibility, qualification, inquiry, and liberating instruction so long as ignorance persists. The witness is actionless, but the empirical knower performs cognition and action.

At *paramartha*, Brahman is one without a second (*ekamevaditiyam*, CU 6.2.1). Separate knowers cannot therefore be finally independent entities. The language of limiting adjuncts (*upadhi*), reflection, and superimposition explains how one consciousness appears as many knowers without undergoing real division. These explanatory models are pedagogically related but should not be treated as a single literal mechanism accepted identically by every Advaita author.

Ishvara is Brahman associated with Maya and functions within *vyavahara* as the omniscient source and governor of ordered name-form manifestation. Advaita commonly treats Ishvara as both material and efficient cause of the empirical universe, not merely an external operative cause and not a creator *ex nihilo*. The individual *jiva* is conditioned by individual ignorance; later pedagogical texts distinguish this from cosmic Maya, although terminology varies across authors. Both distinctions cease at *paramartha*:

> **"These two are the superimpositions of Ishwara and the Jiva respectively, and when these are perfectly eliminated, there is neither Ishwara nor Jiva."**
> *— VC, v. 244*

The *Vivekachudamani* passage is useful evidence for a later pedagogical presentation, but its attribution to Shankara is disputed. The same caution applies to the *Drig-Drishya-Viveka*. They illuminate the received Advaita tradition without replacing the Upanishads, Bhagavad Gita, and Shankara's securely attributed commentaries as primary anchors. Full causal and cosmological comparison appears in The Ontology of Coexistence §§2.4–2.5.

2.5 The nature of the known

Empirical objects, persons, space, time, and causal relations are knowable within the shared world. Their empirical validity is not denied whenever one sees or names them correctly. Advaita denies that their differentiated forms possess self-sufficient reality apart from Brahman. CU 6.1.4 presents the clay analogy: transformations are names grounded in speech, while clay is the material reality through which the transformations are understood.

> **“A firm conviction of the mind to the effect that Brahman is real and the universe unreal, is designated as discrimination (Viveka) between the Real and the unreal.”**
> *— VC, v. 20*
>
> **“The individual soul is itself and directly the Supreme Brahman, and nothing else.”**
> *— VC, v. 216*

The analogy does not make Brahman one more substance among substances. Nor does realization physically destroy the experienced world. It removes the claim that plurality exists independently and absolutely. The liberated person’s continued experience belongs to *vyavahara*; the non-dual standpoint denies that this field establishes a second reality beside Brahman.

2.6 Means of knowledge and liberating instruction

Later systematic Advaita, represented by works such as Dharmaraja’s *Vedanta Paribhasa*, normally accepts six means of valid cognition: perception (*pratyaksha*), inference (*anumana*), comparison (*upamana*), postulation (*arthapatti*), non-apprehension (*anupalabdhi*), and verbal testimony (*shabda*). Earlier Advaita presentations do not always enumerate or analyse them in exactly the same way. This historical qualification matters because the six-fold list is a mature scholastic account, not a verbatim scheme in every foundational text.

The word *pramana* is also a false friend in this comparison. In Advaita and other classical Indian epistemologies it means an instrument or source that generates valid cognition. In Madhyasth Darshan’s English translations, “evidence” or *pramana* often names the lived confirmation of realization in conduct, work, participation, and conveyance. The two uses overlap around warrant but are not equivalent.

Means of cognition	Empirical competence	Limit in Advaita
Perception and inference	Objects, relations, causal and practical judgments	Operate through subject–object distinction
Comparison, postulation, non-apprehension	Linguistic learning, explanatory entailment, warranted absence	Establish empirical cognitions, not non-duality independently
Ordinary testimony	Knowledge received from competent speakers	Remains corrigible within shared life
Upanishadic *shabda*	Reveals the otherwise unavailable identity of Self and Brahman	Does not turn Brahman into a perceptible object

All means of knowledge function for a student within *vyavahara*. Upanishadic testimony is unique not because it operates as a *paramarthika* transaction outside duality, but because it removes ignorance about an identity unavailable to perception and inference. Shankara allows that a qualified student may understand the sentence at first hearing. Reflection (*manana*) removes intellectual doubt, and sustained contemplation (*nididhyasana*) addresses contrary dispositions or obstacles; they do not manufacture the validity of scripture after it was previously invalid.

The pedagogical discipline is conventionally expressed as hearing, reflection, and contemplation under a qualified teacher:

1. ***Shravana*** — hearing and understanding the Upanishadic teaching.
2. ***Manana*** — reasoning that resolves doubts about the teaching.
3. ***Nididhyasana*** — sustained assimilation where habitual contrary identification remains.

> **"The Self, my dear Maitreyi, should be realised—should be heard of, reflected on and meditated upon."**
> *— BU, 2.4.5*

First-person discrimination and *neti neti* (BU, 2.3.6) work within this teaching by withdrawing mistaken identifications. The comparison with Madhyasth Darshan's awakened tradition is therefore structural but limited. Both value an accomplished teacher and assimilated understanding; Advaita treats Upanishadic testimony as the decisive means for non-dual Self-knowledge, whereas Madhyasth Darshan asks realization to become publicly legible in humane conduct and successful conveyance (§1.8).

2.7 Liberation and complete knowledge

Liberating knowledge is not acquisition of a new property or merger of a formerly separate substance into Brahman. It is recognition of the identity taught by *tat tvam asi*, "That thou art" (CU, 6.8.7), through which ignorance of the ever-free Self is removed. BSB 1.1.2 should not be cited as the locus of this identity: it defines Brahman through the origin, continuance, and dissolution of the universe. Shankara's treatment of Upanishadic identity statements occurs across his commentaries and in the later sections of the *Brahma Sutra Bhashya*.

> **“There is neither death nor birth, neither a bound nor a struggling soul, neither a seeker after Liberation nor a liberated one – this is the ultimate truth.”**
> — *VC, v. 574*
>
> **“The Supreme Brahman is, like the sky, pure, absolute, infinite, motionless and changeless, devoid of interior or exterior, the One Existence, without a second, and is one’s own Self.”**
> — *VC, v. 393*

Advaita commonly distinguishes liberation while living (*jivanmukti*) from the final cessation of embodied appearance (*videhamukti*). Knowledge removes ignorance; the body-mind may continue through already-fructifying karma (*prarabdha*) without restoring the knower’s former identification. Accounts differ on the exact explanatory status of *prarabdha*, but the important comparative point is stable: no eternally separate *jiva* persists as an independent knower after liberation. Madhyasth Darshan instead holds that each *jeevan* remains numerically distinct and active in coexistence even when awakened (§1.11).

2.8 Ethics, *loka-sangraha*, and what realization evidences

Advaita does not treat ethical indifference as evidence of realization. The fourfold qualification (*sadhana-catushtaya*) requires discrimination, dispassion, disciplined virtues, and desire for liberation; the Bhagavad Gita’s disciplines of action and devotion purify the mind for knowledge. In Shankara’s account, action does not directly produce liberation, because an action cannot create the already existent Self. Ethical and contemplative disciplines prepare the knower, while knowledge removes ignorance.

The Bhagavad Gita’s explicit discussion of *loka-sangraha*, sustaining or protecting the world’s order, occurs at 3.20 and 3.25–26. Shankara allows that one who has no personal end left to gain may nevertheless act for the welfare and guidance of others. BG 3.8 establishes the necessity of prescribed action for the unliberated agent, but it should not carry the whole claim about enlightened social responsibility.

Domain	Valid at *vyavahara*	Status at *paramartha*
Ethics and duty	Required for qualification and social order (BG 3.8, 3.20, 3.25–26)	No separate agent remains with a personal end to achieve
World and nature	Law-governed, shared, beginningless cosmology	*Mithya* — dependent appearance
Individual self	Real as embodied *jiva* under *upadhi*	Identical with Brahman; separateness dispelled

Domain	Valid at *vyavahara*	Status at *paramartha*
Relationships and society	*Loka-sangraha*, ordained action for world-welfare	Not ultimately separate from Brahman
Time and change	Past, present, future, birth and death operationally valid	Sublated when timeless Self is known

Madhyasth Darshan's objection is therefore not that Advaita lacks ethical discipline or compassionate exemplars. It is that ethical action has a different epistemic and ontological place. In Madhyasth Darshan, mutually fulfilling conduct is constitutive public evidence of understanding in a perpetually real coexistence. In Advaita, ethical fitness prepares the mind and compassionate action may express freedom, but neither produces Self-knowledge nor makes relationships ultimately independent realities. The dispute concerns what conduct proves and what final weight the world retains.

2.9 Scope within Indian epistemology

Advaita is one major Indian answer, not a proxy for Indian epistemology as a whole. Nyaya defends enduring individual selves, a realist world, and a highly articulated theory of inference and testimony. Mimamsa develops distinctive accounts of linguistic authority and the intrinsic or extrinsic validity of cognition. Buddhist epistemologists analyse perception, inference, momentariness, and no-self without accepting Advaita's Brahman. A comprehensive cross-Indian comparison would therefore require a separate study. Advaita is retained here because its witness analysis, non-dual absolute, and theory of liberating knowledge create the sharpest contrast with Madhyasth Darshan's enduring plural knowers in coexistence.

3. Modern Western Epistemology and Philosophy of Mind

Modern Western philosophy offers no single answer to knowledge, knower, and known. Analytic epistemology asks what turns true belief into knowledge; philosophy of mind disputes whether the knower is wholly physical, emergent, embodied, socially constituted, or grounded in consciousness; phenomenological and perspectival approaches begin from lived experience rather than treating it as an afterthought. Physicalism is influential, but it is a contested philosophical position rather than the unanimous conclusion of analytic philosophy.

3.1 What is knowledge?

Analytic epistemology usually distinguishes **propositional knowledge**—knowing that something is the case—from knowledge-how, acquaintance, and understanding. The traditional justified-true-belief framework concerns propositional knowledge. Gettier (1963) showed that a belief may be justified and true through epistemic luck without amounting to knowledge, so contemporary accounts add or replace conditions involving reliability, safety, proper function, evidence, or intellectual competence.

Reliabilism locates warrant partly in dependable belief-forming processes rather than only in reasons accessible to reflection (Goldman 1979). Virtue epistemology treats knowledge as a success attributable to the knower's intellectual competence (Sosa 2007). Social epistemology examines testimony, trust, disagreement, institutions, and epistemic injustice, showing why an isolated individual is not the sole unit of assessment (Fricker 2007; Jarczewski and Riggs 2025). These theories compete; "modern Western epistemology" has no single accepted criterion.

Madhyasth Darshan's *gyan* does not map neatly onto any one of these categories. It includes understanding of coexistence and the human being, realization by the knower, and confirmation in conduct (§§1.1–1.8). Analytic epistemology can ask whether its claims are true, warranted, reliably formed, communicable, and socially responsible, but it will not ordinarily define humane conduct as part of what makes a proposition known. Scientific method, meanwhile, is an institutional way of producing and correcting empirical knowledge; it belongs to §4 rather than serving as the definition of knowledge in analytic epistemology.

3.2 Naturalistic accounts of the knower

Physicalist and naturalistic accounts identify knowing with capacities of embodied organisms or with cognitive processes realized by them (Churchland 1986; Dennett 1991). Some theories reduce mental states to physical or functional states; others treat consciousness and selfhood as emergent, embodied, enacted, or distributed across organism and environment. They agree less about consciousness than the label "naturalism" can suggest.

Many physicalists reject a Cartesian inner observer. On representational accounts, the self is a dynamically maintained self-model integrating perception, memory, bodily regulation, action, and social recognition. Enactive and embodied accounts resist the picture of a brain constructing an inner replica for a detached spectator; they locate cognition in skilled organism–environment engagement. Both differ from an indivisible *jeevan*, though for different reasons.

The causal closure of the physical is a philosophical thesis used in arguments for physicalism (Kim 2005), not a separately measured law stating that every event already has a sufficient physical cause. Conservation laws constrain physical quantities, but by themselves do not settle the metaphysics of mind or show that intention would have to "inject energy." The sharper challenge to Madhyasth Darshan is explanatory: if *jeevan* is distinct from the body yet affects neural action, the account needs a publicly assessable relation between its activities and measured brain processes. Without such criteria, physicalism remains contestable while *jeevan* remains empirically underdetermined.

3.3 Scientific realism and the scope of the known

Scientific realism is a philosophical interpretation of successful science: well-confirmed theories aim to describe a mind-independent world, including unobservable entities supported by explanatory and predictive success. Instrumentalists and constructive empiricists grant the practical and empirical success of theories without making the same commitment to their unobservable ontology. Science itself does not decide this dispute by methodological fiat.

The scientifically investigated world includes physical, biological, psychological, and social phenomena insofar as claims about them can be made publicly answerable to evidence. Public does not mean directly visible or purely quantitative: scientists infer unobservables, use models and instruments, and can treat disciplined first-person reports as data when collection and interpretation are calibrated. Spacetime in physics remains a mathematically articulated dynamical structure, not omnipresent knowledge-energy (The Ontology of Coexistence §4.5; *Nature of Time*).

Madhyasth Darshan expands the known to include relationship, value, *dharma*, and humane order as objective dimensions of coexistence (§1.10). Western philosophy contains realist and anti-realist accounts of value, while psychology and social science investigate moral cognition and institutions. Descriptive findings alone do not entail prescriptive conclusions without normative premises. The comparison should therefore oppose neither "physical facts" to "values" nor science to all normativity; it should ask what kind of evidence supports claims that values are features of reality rather than human responses, practices, or constructions.

3.4 The hard problem, mystery, and first-person evidence

Philosophy of mind distinguishes explanatory questions from the analysis of knowledge. Third-person accounts are powerful on mechanism and prediction, yet Chalmers's **hard problem** asks why and how physical processing is accompanied by subjective experience (Chalmers 1995; Nagel 1974):

> **"The really hard problem of consciousness is the problem of experience."**
> *— Chalmers 1995, p. 3*
>
> **"the fact that an organism has conscious experience at all means, basically, that there is something it is like to be that organism."**
> *— Nagel 1974, p. 1*

The argument begins from the reality of experience, but its conclusion is disputed. Reductive physicalists expect a functional or neuroscientific explanation; illusionists argue that the apparently ineffable properties attributed to consciousness are products of introspective representation (Frankish 2016); non-reductive physicalists treat experience as irreducible without making it a separate substance; panpsychists or Russellian monists assign experience or proto-experiential character a fundamental role (Strawson 2006; Goff 2019; Hashemi 2025).

These are philosophical positions constrained by science, not established findings of consciousness science.

The hard problem does not prove an extra-physical *jeevan*, and neural correlation does not by itself solve the hard problem. Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger proposal: mystery (*rahasyata*) is a removable deficit in the knower's reflection, and disciplined realization can disclose the constitution and activity of the knower (§1.9). Comparative evaluation must therefore ask what such realization predicts, how it is distinguished from introspective error, and how first-person discrimination is coordinated with public evidence.

3.5 Error, bias, and epistemic correction

Western epistemology distinguishes several failures that should not be merged. A belief may be false, accidentally true, irresponsibly held, produced by an unreliable process, distorted by bias, or defeated by evidence the believer ignores. Testimonial injustice and institutional exclusion add social failures that cannot be located only inside an individual's reasoning. Gettier cases concern epistemic luck even when belief is justified and true; they are not examples of experimental non-replication.

Scientific practices address a subset of these failures through calibration, controls, statistical criticism, replication, adversarial testing, and revision. Phenomenology addresses another subset by examining how objects and selfhood are given in experience; psychotherapy, contemplative disciplines, and moral education address still others. None supplies an infallible correction regime.

Madhyasth Darshan foregrounds false learning, delusion, and contradiction between claimed understanding and conduct (§1.9). Advaita foregrounds superimposition and ignorance of Self (§2.3). Analytic epistemology asks whether belief is warranted and non-accidental, while science asks whether empirical claims survive public tests. The live comparison is not first-person against third-person correction, but how different kinds of error are diagnosed and how their proposed corrections become independently assessable.

3.6 Personal identity and brain death

Physicalism's answer to post-mortem persistence is typically negative: if personal capacities are realized by a living brain and organism, their irreversible destruction ends the person. Clinical criteria of death serve medical and legal decisions; they are not themselves a complete philosophical theory of personal identity. No reproducible public evidence has established the continued agency of an individual knower after bodily death.

Personal identity theory asks what, if anything, makes a person the same individual over time. Locke tied identity to **psychological continuity** — memory and connectedness of consciousness — rather than sameness of material particles. Parfit (1984) argued that what matters in survival is psychological connectedness, not a further fact of deep identity beyond the stream of mental states. On reductionist readings, the question "is this the same knower after death?” has no fact of the matter beyond causal and psychological links — which bodily death breaks (SEP Personal Identity).

Madhyasth Darshan’s *jeevan* (§1.11) and Advaita’s eternal *Atman* (§§2.4 and 2.7) both reject this outcome on different grounds. Physicalism sets a high evidential bar: without operational criteria for a non-neural knower or independent post-death evidence, immortal *jeevan* remains a metaphysical posit, while the hard problem (§3.4) exposes the incompleteness of current physical explanation without proving either rival view.

3.7 Social, embodied, and perspectival knowing

Phenomenology begins from intentionality: consciousness is consciousness *of* something, and objects are disclosed through embodied, temporal, and perspectival experience. Husserl’s suspension of the natural attitude is a methodological refusal to settle metaphysics before describing experience, not the Advaita conclusion that the experienced world is *mithya*. Merleau-Ponty’s embodied subject is not a detached witness behind the body; bodily orientation is constitutive of perceptual access to a shared world (SEP Phenomenology).

Embodied and enactive approaches carry part of this insight into cognitive science by treating cognition as skilled activity of organism and environment rather than passive construction of an inner picture. Perspectival realism holds that scientific knowledge is historically, instrumentally, and conceptually situated while remaining capable of truth about a mind-independent world (Massimi 2022). These positions give the knower’s standpoint a constructive role without making truth merely private.

Social epistemology adds that testimony, trust, expertise, institutions, and relations of power affect what people can responsibly know. It comes closer to Madhyasth Darshan’s emphasis on tradition and conveyance, but it evaluates testimonial competence and social conditions rather than presupposing an awakened lineage. The comparison is therefore not exhausted by “matter versus soul.” It also concerns whether knowledge is belief, reliable competence, lived disclosure, social achievement, understanding, or conduct-evidenced realization—and how first-person and public evidence constrain one another.

4. Modern Scientific Approaches

The natural sciences operationalise knowledge through observation, measurement, modelling, prediction, experiment, and replication. They do not ordinarily define a metaphysical knower. They investigate organisms, brains, behaviour, reports, and environments, while adopting methodological naturalism: explanations are sought in publicly testable processes rather than in unmeasured sentient units.

4.1 Method and means of knowing

Natural science adopts methodological naturalism: it seeks explanations through publicly testable processes without requiring a prior proof that only natural entities exist.

Measurement, formal models, experiment, and institutional criticism extend ordinary perception and inference (Popper 1959). Science can constrain philosophical accounts of mind, but an experimental result does not by itself select a complete metaphysics. SB likewise records that humans seek to live with evidence through experimentation, behaviour, and experience (SB, p. 44); Madhyasth Darshan extends that demand into realization and conduct (The Ontology of Coexistence §4).

The principal scientific practices do not map one-to-one onto Indian *pramana* lists, although some functions are comparable:

Modern source	Primary role	Limits for mind/self claims
Perception (incl. instruments)	Data acquisition from world and body	Theory-laden; does not directly observe non-physical *jeevan*
Inference and modelling	Hypothesis, prediction, mathematical structure	Multiple models may fit the same data; ontology requires further argument
Measurement and experiment	Controlled test of predictions	**Experiment** here means hypothesis-testing and replication — not Madhyasth Darshan's wider verification in production and lived orderliness (§1.7)
Testimony and trust	Collective knowledge via experts, records, education	Depends on epistemic communities; social virtue epistemology develops this (§3.7)
Replication and review	Error control across communities	Reliability varies by design, incentives, and access to evidence

Public accountability, rather than a ban on first-person evidence, is the governing standard. Pain ratings, perceptual reports, introspective confidence, and phenomenological interviews can enter research as data, but their elicitation and interpretation must be open to calibration and criticism. First-person experience is indispensable to consciousness research; it is not by itself evidence for immortal units or sufficient warrant for a metaphysical theory.

4.2 Brain, organism, and conscious report

Neuroscience establishes systematic dependence between brain activity and perception, memory, language, decision, and conscious report (Kandel et al. 2021). Injury, stimulation, anaesthesia, development, and degeneration alter the capacities attributed to a knower. These findings support brain-based accounts, but dependence does not by itself settle whether consciousness is identical with neural activity, emerges from it, or accompanies it under a deeper ontology.

Madhyasth Darshan accepts the brain as the body's enriched signal-processing organ while assigning understanding and evaluation to *jeevan* (§1.4). The scientific question is whether that distinction predicts anything beyond brain–behaviour models. A viable empirical programme would need operational markers of *jeevan*, not only philosophical dissatisfaction with physicalism.

4.3 Consciousness science and unresolved theory

Consciousness science contains competing research programmes, including global neuronal workspace, integrated information, higher-order, recurrent-processing, and predictive-processing accounts. Illusionism and panpsychism are broader philosophical interpretations, not programmes of the same experimental kind. Adversarial testing of IIT and GNWT has challenged distinctive predictions of both rather than selecting an uncontested winner (Melloni et al. 2025). This pluralism shows an unfinished explanatory field, not positive evidence for Madhyasth Darshan.

The hard problem remains the philosophical question of why physical processing should have a first-person aspect at all (§3.4). Experimental science can map neural correlates, behavioural capacities, and report conditions without resolving that metaphysical question. Madhyasth Darshan offers *jeevan* as its answer, but the existence and interaction of such a unit remain to be independently established.

4.4 Error control and public evidence

Scientific error correction depends on calibrated instruments, statistical discipline, replication, peer review, and adversarial testing. Its strength is that results need not depend on the moral or contemplative attainment of a particular observer. Its limits are equally clear: institutional procedures can reproduce shared assumptions, and third-person measures do not exhaust the first-person character of experience or the normative question of how knowledge should guide conduct.

Madhyasth Darshan's evidence chain and scientific replication therefore overlap only partly. Both require claims to face consequence and correction. Science privileges methodologically reproducible observations; Madhyasth Darshan additionally requires coherence among realisation, behaviour, work, relationship, and transmission (§1.7). The latter is broader, but breadth does not automatically supply the controls against suggestion, authority, and confirmation bias that science has developed.

4.5 Ethics, value, and life's purpose

Evolutionary biology can explain how cooperation, kin concern, punishment, and norm sensitivity developed; psychology and social science investigate empathy, reasoning, institutions, and cultural variation. These are explanations of capacities and practices, not by themselves proofs that a moral norm is true. Philosophical naturalists consequently divide among moral realism, constructivism, contractualism, expressivism, and error theory.

Survival and reproduction describe central consequences of natural selection, not a scientifically prescribed purpose for a human life. Purposes involving relationship, vocation, inquiry, justice, or flourishing require practical and ethical judgment. Science can illuminate their conditions and consequences but does not establish a single cosmic telos of awakening, liberation, or realization in coexistence.

Madhyasth Darshan makes a stronger unity claim: value, humane purpose, knowledge, and conduct belong to the objective order of coexistence and confirm one another (§1.6). The scientific and philosophical challenge is to show how this normative order is known, how disagreement is corrected, and why successful conduct supports its ontology rather than only its practical usefulness.

4.6 Beyond simple brain reduction

Cognitive science is not restricted to a passive input–computation–output picture. Predictive-processing and active-inference approaches model an organism as anticipating sensory causes and acting to maintain viable states (Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013; Wiese 2024; Tufft et al. 2024). Embodied and enactive research instead emphasizes sensorimotor skill, bodily regulation, and environmental coupling (IEP Enactivism; Piredda 2024). Both make agency more distributed than a brain-only slogan suggests, while remaining compatible with naturalistic investigation.

Research that coordinates careful experiential reports with neural and behavioural measures offers a possible bridge between first-person and public evidence. Such work does not treat introspection as infallible: reports are trained, sampled, compared, and related to independently measured processes. This is methodologically closer to Madhyasth Darshan's demand that inner realization meet observable consequences, although it does not presuppose *jeevan* or humane conduct as the ontology and criterion of consciousness.

These developments leave open whether cognition is best described as representational or enactive, brain-bound or organism–environmental, and reducible or irreducible. They do not remove the principal scientific objection to Madhyasth Darshan: a distinct *jeevan* has no agreed operational marker that discriminates its contribution from brain–body dynamics.

Public science has established precise mechanism, prediction, and correction across many domains. It has not established immortal *jeevan* or post-death continuity of a sentient unit (§§1.11 and 7.4). An explanatory gap in consciousness is not an existence proof for *jeevan*; predictive accuracy alone does not settle whether the regulator is only neural or a distinct unit working through the brain (§7.3).

5. Comparison

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural sciences
Knowledge	Realised understanding of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct, evidenced through wisdom, science, and living	Valid empirical cognition at *vyavahara*; liberating knowledge of Self–Brahman identity	Propositional warrant, reliable competence, understanding, lived disclosure, or social achievement	Models and explanations supported by observation, prediction, experiment, and replication
Knower	*Jeevan* as active sentient bearer; human joint form as embodied evidence	Embodied *jiva* is empirical knower; *sakshin* illumines cognition; separate knower is sublated at *paramartha*	Organism, embodied subject, socially constituted person, or consciousness, depending on theory	Operationally, the organism and its measurable brain, behaviour, reports, and environment
Known	Coexistence as object; made meaningful through awakened human and *jeevan* aspirations	Empirical plurality at *vyavahara*; Brahman alone at *paramartha*	Mind-independent reality, experience, concepts, or socially mediated objects, depending on theory	Publicly investigable physical, biological, and behavioural processes
Method	Study, reflection, practice, behaviour, experiment, evaluation, and transmission	*Shravana*, *manana*, *nididhyasana*, and contemplative discrimination	Argument, phenomenological description, conceptual analysis, testimony, and epistemic practice	Measurement, modelling, controlled experiment, prediction, replication, and review

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural sciences
Validation	Realisation and authenticity made evident in behaviour, work, relationship, and teachable tradition	Empirical *pramanas* in their domains; Upanishadic *shabda* removes ignorance of identity	Justification, reliability, virtue, coherence, safety, or perspectival adequacy	Reproducible evidence and successful prediction under public methods
Error	Body–*jeevan* identification, incomplete faculty activity, false learning, and mis-evaluation	Superimposition and *anirvacaniya* error, sublated by knowledge	False belief, unreliable process, conceptual confusion, or situated distortion	Measurement error, bias, failed prediction, confounding, and non-replication
World status	Real and perpetual	Empirically valid but ultimately *mithya*	Realist, idealist, pragmatist, and anti-realist positions compete	Investigated as a stable public order; final metaphysics is not fixed by method alone
Conduct	Humane conduct is content and evidence of knowledge	Ethical discipline prepares and expresses realisation at *vyavahara*	Ethics and epistemic virtue are related but normally distinct from possessing knowledge	Ethical purpose is not derivable from descriptive results alone
Persistence	*Jeevan* persists across bodily death; asserted and inferred, not scientifically measured	Self is eternal Brahman; separate *jiva* is ultimately unreal	Substance, bodily, psychological, narrative, and reductionist accounts compete	Personal continuity is ordinarily tied to continuing brain and organism function

Question	Madhyasth Darshan	Advaita Vedanta	Modern Western philosophy	Natural sciences
Goal	Happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss; resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence	*Moksha* through knowledge of non-duality	Truth, rational agency, understanding, flourishing, or intellectual virtue	Explanation, prediction, intervention, and corrigible public knowledge

5.1 Key contrasts

The deepest ontological contrast is between perpetual plurality and non-dual dependence. Madhyasth Darshan holds Space and every material and sentient unit to be real in coexistence: *Brahma satya hai, jagat satat hai*. Advaita grants the world empirical validity but denies it independent absolute reality. Science investigates a stable public order without, by method alone, deciding between every realist and anti-realist interpretation; it offers no evidence that physical spacetime is omnipresent knowledge.

The accounts of the knower must be compared at matching levels. Advaita's empirical *jiva* perceives, reasons, acts, and bears responsibility; the witness is actionless and illumines these activities; at *paramartha*, no separate knower remains. Madhyasth Darshan's *jeevan* remains a distinct active sentient unit in both ignorance and awakening. Naturalistic approaches locate activity in brain, body, environment, and social practice. The contrast is therefore not simply an active knower against a passive one, but enduring plural agency against empirically operative agency whose separateness is finally sublated.

Knowledge and conduct also occupy different logical roles. Madhyasth Darshan places humane conduct within complete knowledge and treats its expression in behaviour, work, relationship, and conveyance as evidence (§§1.2 and 1.7). Advaita requires ethical qualification and permits liberated action for *loka-sangraha*, but conduct neither produces nor constitutes *brahma-jnana*. Western virtue and social epistemology connect knowing with competence and responsibility, while natural science evaluates claims through publicly corrigible methods rather than the moral attainment of a claimant.

The four approaches diagnose different primary errors. Madhyasth Darshan identifies incomplete or misdirected activity of *jeevan* and contradiction between realization and conduct. Advaita identifies superimposition of body-mind and Self, removed by Upanishadic knowledge. Analytic epistemology distinguishes falsehood, luck, unreliable formation, and social distortion; science institutionalizes controls against measurement error, confounding, bias, and failed prediction. A comparative test must ask whether each method can detect the errors to which its own practitioners are vulnerable.

5.2 Sat-Chit-Ananda versus distributed coexistence

Advaita's Sat-Chit-Ananda and Madhyasth Darshan's coexistence can sound alike — both speak of being, consciousness, and fulfilment. The contrast is over what those words name and whether the world survives them (The Ontology of Coexistence §5.6).

Concept	Advaita Vedanta (unified non-dualism)	Madhyasth Darshan (distributed coexistence)
Sat (Being)	Brahman is independent reality; names and forms have dependent empirical reality.	Beingness (*astitva*) is coexistence of formless Omnipresence and countless real units.
Chit (Consciousness)	Self-revealing consciousness identical with Self and Brahman; empirical mind and objects are not independently conscious.	Omnipresence is pervasive knowledge or condition of intelligibility (§1.1), while active sentience (*chaitanya*) belongs to each *jeevan*.
Ananda (Fullness or bliss)	Limitless fullness of Brahman, not a passing mental pleasure.	Harmony realized within awakened *jeevan* and expressed as humane conduct.

Modern philosophy has no parallel formula: it may treat experience as physical, fundamental, or illusory, but it does not name existence as Sat-Chit-Ananda or as coexistence.

5.3 Partially incommensurable epistemic criteria

The four approaches do not merely give different answers; they use different criteria for what counts as knowing:

Tradition	Method	Adequate for
Madhyasth Darshan	Study, realization, behaviour, experiment	Coexistence as lived evidence; conduct as proof of understanding
Advaita	Upanishadic testimony, reasoning, and contemplative discrimination (§§2.1–2.7)	Valid empirical cognition and removal of ignorance of Self–Brahman identity
Modern Western philosophy	Argument, experience, justification, reliability, virtue, and social practice (§3)	Conceptual warrant and accounts of first- and third-person knowing
Natural sciences	Observation, modelling, replication, peer review (§4)	Mechanism, prediction, and public correction

They are partially incommensurable because each includes standards the others do not fully recognise. Comparison can nevertheless test internal consistency, fidelity to experience, fit with public knowledge, explanatory reach, and whether a claimed method controls its own characteristic errors. The remaining disputes are collected in §7.

6. Critical Review

No view escapes serious objections. Here is where each is strong and where each is vulnerable.

6.1 Madhyasth Darshan — integrated inside, unproven outside

Strengths.

- It integrates ontology, active selfhood, knowledge, action, value, and social evidence rather than treating epistemology as belief assessment alone.
- KD's linked triads connect perspective, realization, action, result, and evaluation; conduct therefore has genuine epistemic weight.
- Its realism preserves the final significance of nature, individual sentient units, and human relationships.

Weaknesses.

- The claims that Omnipresence is Knowledge and that a constitutionally complete atom is the knower are not independently established by physical measurement.
- The relation between *jeevan* and measured brain activity remains underspecified (§7.3).
- Conduct-evidence does not yet discriminate Madhyasth Darshan's ontology from rival paths that also produce resolution or humane action.
- The method needs safeguards against circularity when awakening validates the teaching and the teaching identifies awakening, as well as a clearer boundary between structural certitude and corrigible empirical knowledge (§§7.1 and 7.5).

Madhyasth Darshan is best read as an internally integrated epistemology whose decisive tests remain conduct-based and publicly contestable, not as a demonstrated ontology.

6.2 Advaita Vedanta — disciplined self-inquiry, disputed non-duality

Strengths.

- Advaita distinguishes ordinary cognition from the consciousness in whose presence cognition is manifest, preventing a simple identification of the knower with any passing mental state.
- Its analysis of superimposition explains how bodily, affective, and cognitive predicates become fused with the sense of self.

- Its account of empirical *pramanas*, qualified instruction, reasoning, and contemplation is more epistemically articulated than a generic appeal to mystical experience.
- Ethical discipline and *loka-sangraha* answer the claim that non-duality simply licenses withdrawal from empirical responsibility.

Weaknesses.

- Its move from the non-objectifiability of witnessing consciousness to identity with Brahman requires Upanishadic testimony and interpretive argument; introspection alone does not establish cosmic non-duality.
- The relation of beginningless ignorance to non-dual Brahman remains contested. Calling *avidya* dependent and neither absolutely real nor sheer non-being protects non-duality, but critics can still ask whether this explains the appearance of plurality or restates its anomalous status.
- The empirical validity of suffering, duty, and relationship supports serious ethics, yet their final sublation gives them a different ontological standing from the perpetual relations asserted by Madhyasth Darshan.
- Later Advaita models of *jiva*, reflection, Maya, and levels of reality are not uniform; comparison must not treat one scholastic formulation as the uncontested view of the entire tradition.

Advaita offers a rigorous account of liberating Self-knowledge when its empirical and absolute levels are kept distinct. Its central comparative vulnerability is not ethical incapacity but the additional argument needed to move from witness analysis to non-dual metaphysics, together with the final dependence it assigns to the plural world.

6.3 Modern Western philosophy — plural resources, no settled knower

Strengths.

- Analytic epistemology supplies precise tools for justification, reliability, testimony, intellectual competence, epistemic luck, and social error.
- Phenomenology and embodied approaches describe lived and bodily access to the world without reducing experience to an afterthought.
- Social epistemology explains why testimony, institutions, trust, and power partly constitute the conditions under which individuals know.

Weaknesses.

- The plurality of approaches can fragment the relation among warranted belief, consciousness, understanding, value, and conduct.
- A theory may explain when a proposition counts as known without explaining the nature of the subject who knows it.

- Physicalist, phenomenological, enactive, idealist, and social accounts can share vocabulary while disagreeing about what the knower and known ultimately are.

Modern Western philosophy makes the conceptual alternatives explicit but does not deliver a single replacement for the integrated Madhyasth Darshan triad.

6.4 Natural sciences — powerful correction, bounded scope

Strengths.

- Measurement, intervention, prediction, replication, and adversarial testing provide powerful controls against individual conviction being mistaken for public knowledge.
- Neuroscience establishes detailed dependencies among brain, body, behaviour, report, and cognitive capacity without requiring premature agreement on a final metaphysics of consciousness.
- Public methods enable correction across observers, instruments, cultures, and generations.

Weaknesses.

- **The hard problem.** Neural dependence and correlation do not yet explain why physical processing has a first-person aspect (§§3.4 and 4.3).
- **First-person calibration.** Reports and experiential descriptions can enter science, but their public calibration may omit aspects of experience that are difficult to operationalize; no agreed method fully coordinates phenomenological structure with neural explanation (§§3.4 and 4.1).
- **Normative limitation.** Descriptive success does not by itself establish justice, humane purpose, or the values by which knowledge should be used (§4.5).
- **Theory competition.** Consciousness science has several live but competing programmes and no settled account of the knower (§4.3).

The natural sciences offer the strongest method for public correction, but the claim that their current ontology is the complete account of knowledge and the knower remains philosophical rather than an experimental result.

7. Open problems for Madhyasth Darshan epistemology

7.1 Holistic knowability versus fallibilism

Madhyasth Darshan holds that the structure of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct can be understood without ontological mystery (§1.9). It does not follow that an awakened person knows every contingent fact. The system needs a clearer account of which claims are held with final certitude, which remain open to empirical correction, and how mistaken certainty would be diagnosed from within the method.

7.2 Conduct-evidence and public testability

Realisation, authenticity, behaviour, experiment, and transmission form Madhyasth Darshan 's evidence regime (§1.7). Science requires operational and reproducible discrimination among competing explanations. Public evaluation of *jeevan* would require at minimum:

1. **Operational criteria** for constitutional completeness independent of the philosophy.
2. **Reproducible markers** distinguishing *jeevan*-mediated from brain-only activity.
3. **Independent evidence** for post-death continuity of a sentient unit.

Until then, immortal *jeevan* remains a metaphysical commitment not validated by current science. Realisation as *pramana* is an epistemic criterion, not itself a metaphysical entity; the open question is whether its conduct and transmission tests can distinguish Madhyasth Darshan's ontology from rival paths that also produce resolution or ethical conduct. The explanatory gap in consciousness is not by itself evidence for *jeevan*.

7.3 *Jeevan*–body interaction and physical causation

If *jeevan* coordinates the body through the joint form (§1.4), either it makes a measurable difference to neural activity or "driving" names a non-mechanical relation that still requires specification. The texts' signal language is more precise than a crude Cartesian push, but it does not yet answer the closure-based objection or show what observations would differ if *jeevan* were absent.

7.4 Post-death continuity as inference, not measurement

Post-death survival of *jeevan* is inferred from constitutional completeness and conservation (§1.11), not established by third-person observation. Quantity conservation alone does not guarantee entity identity. Madhyasth Darshan's account of liberation from molecular- and weight-bondage must therefore carry the argument and remains an open point of contact with physics and mereology (The Ontology of Coexistence §6.2.3).

7.5 Teacher, tradition, and circular validation

Madhyasth Darshan requires guidance from a realised human and treats successful conveyance as evidence (§1.8). This creates a productive second-person discipline but also a circularity risk: the teacher may be recognised as realised through the doctrine, while the doctrine is trusted through the teacher. The tradition needs explicit safeguards for disagreement, failed transmission, authority error, and correction of a respected teacher.

7.6 Non-substitutable evidence across domains

The darshan expects coherence across realisation, thought, relationship, work, result, and social participation. It does not yet state a public rule for cases in which the domains diverge: sound conduct with disputed metaphysics, contemplative certitude with failed prediction, or successful production with unjust relationships. CFP's recovery audit suggests the right discipline — success in one domain must not silently substitute for failure in another — but the criteria for adjudicating such mixed cases remain to be developed in ordinary prose and practice.

8. Conclusion

Madhyasth Darshan's distinctive contribution to comparative epistemology is not merely an additional definition of knowledge. It joins the intelligibility of coexistence, *jeevan* as the active knower, humane conduct as part of what must be known, and the consequences of action as evidence that returns to the knower. Knowledge, knower, and known become complete together when understanding is stable across realisation, thought, relationship, work, evaluation, and transmission. This gives epistemology an ethical and civilisational reach that neither belief-centred analysis nor mechanism-centred science ordinarily claims.

The comparison also fixes the limits of that contribution. Advaita offers a more radical account of the witness by dissolving the triad at the highest level; Madhyasth Darshan preserves the distinction and participation of real units within coexistence. Modern Western philosophy provides plural accounts of warrant, embodiment, first-person experience, and social knowledge. Natural science supplies the strongest available procedures for public correction and causal explanation. Madhyasth Darshan must therefore show how realisation and conduct-evidence control error without circularity, and how claims about *jeevan* differ observationally from biological accounts.

The primary texts support a richer epistemic structure than the simple formula "knowledge–knower–known" suggests: seeing, attention, action, and seeking; knowing, believing, recognising, fulfilling, and evaluating; projection and reflection; seer, doer, and enjoyer; karma, result, and transmission. Those relations should govern future revision and formal work. The unresolved questions do not erase the framework's coherence, but they mark where philosophical exposition must be joined by clearer tests, intersubjective safeguards, and dialogue with the sciences.

Appendix: Quick Glossary

Key terms from §§1–4 are collected here for quick reference. Each term is also defined where it first appears in the exposition.

Terms in §1

Term	Plain meaning
Coexistence (*saha-astitva*)	Reality as the pervasive ground (*satta*) and all units (*ikai*) inseparably present together.

Term	Plain meaning
***Anubhav jnan* (Realisation Knowledge)**	Saturated insentient and sentient nature, whose units have form, properties, essential nature, *dharma*, and orderliness (MVD, p. 11; §1.1).
Gyan udghatan	The unfolding of knowledge through awakened humans or the sentient aspect, not cognition performed by Omnipresence (§1.1).
Gyan-vivek-vigyan	Knowledge, wisdom/discrimination, and science/systematic know-how — the way understanding becomes evaluation and practical participation.
Knowledge–knower–known	Knowledge of coexistence, *jeevan*, and humane conduct; *jeevan* as bearer of knowing; coexistence as object made meaningful in awakened living (§1.2).
Drish–drishya–darshan / drishti	KD’s technical trio assigns *drish* to *jeevan* as seeing subject, *drishya* to coexistence as the seen, and *darshan* to its meaningful exposition; MVD uses *drishti* for perspective (§1.3).
***Sapekshata* (Relativity)**	The differentiation that arises among perspective, observed scene, and worldview; not the unreality of coexistence (§1.3).
Sanvedansheelta* / *sangyansheelta	Sensitivity (body- and sense-based responsiveness) and comprehension/cognisance (the understanding proper to *jeevan*) — the two modes of engaging the world.
Pramana	Means or proof of valid knowledge; in Madhyasth Darshan, realization (*anubhav*) evidenced in conduct is the ultimate proof.
***Pramanikta* (Authenticity)**	The realisation-bearing activity of *atma* that becomes publicly evident through conduct, teaching, and humane tradition (§1.7).
Projection / reflection	The evidencing and knowing directions of *jeevan*’s ten coordinated activities (§1.4).
Seer–doer–enjoyer	Understanding, action, and fruition unified in the awakened human joint form (§1.6).
Bhram	Delusion — living by inherited belief rather than understanding, rooted in identifying *jeevan* with the body.
***Rahasyata* (Mysteriousness)**	Incapacity to attain, evidence, or impart complete understanding (§1.9).
***Bauddhik rahasya* (Intellectual mystery)**	Failure of reflection and alignment among the faculties of *jeevan* (§1.9).

Term	Plain meaning
***Anushandhan* (Exploration)**	Inventive comprehensive study from decline through development and awakening to Omnipresence (MVD, Ch. 17; §1.8).
Jeevan	The sentient self — in Shri Nagraj's view a real, eternal, atom-scale entity that works *through* the body. Ontology: [The Ontology of Coexistence]().
***Drishta-pad* (Seer status)**	The unique capacity of the human being in existence to observe, understand, and evaluate all orders of nature.
Human aspiration	Resolution, prosperity, fearlessness, and coexistence at person, family, society, and universal-order scales (§1.6).
***Jeevan* aspiration**	Happiness, peace, contentment, and bliss as harmonies of *jeevan* (§1.6).

Terms in §2

Term	Plain meaning
Atman* / *Brahman	In Advaita Vedanta: the innermost Self / the one ultimate, non-dual reality.
Pramatr–pramana–prameya–prama	Empirical knower, means of valid cognition, known object, and resulting valid cognition; this structure operates at *vyavahara* (§§2.1 and 2.6).
Jiva	The embodied empirical knower and agent under ignorance; its apparent separateness is sublated in liberating knowledge.
Sakshin	The actionless witnessing consciousness that illumines changing cognitions without becoming another empirical cognitive instrument.
Sat-Chit-Ananda	A later compact Advaita expression for Brahman as existence, consciousness, and limitless fullness; related to but not identical with TU 2.1.1's wording.
Chit	Advaita: consciousness as the very nature of Brahman and the inner Self.
Svaprakasha	Advaita: consciousness self-luminous — reveals itself without another knower (§2.2).
***Badha* (Sublation)**	Cancellation of a cognition or claim to independent reality by a cognition with greater authority (§2.3).

Term	Plain meaning
Mithya	Dependent empirical reality: neither independently absolute nor sheer non-being.
Moksha	Advaita: liberation as recognition of pre-existing identity with Brahman (§2.7).

Terms in §3

Term	Plain meaning
Scientific realism	The view that successful scientific theories aim to describe a mind-independent world, including well-supported unobservable entities (§3.3).
Hard Problem	Why physical brain processes are accompanied by subjective experience — a modern open question, not the same as Madhyasth Darshan's *rahasyata* (§1.9; §3.4).

Terms in §4

Term	Plain meaning
Methodological naturalism	The scientific policy of seeking publicly testable natural explanations without assuming that current physicalism is complete.
Replication	Independent repetition of a method or test as a control on error and investigator-specific conviction (§4.4).
Neural correlate	A brain state or process systematically associated with a conscious capacity or report; correlation alone does not decide metaphysical identity (§4.2).

References

Madhyasth Darshan (primary sources)

- **MVD** — Nagraj, A. *Madhyasth Darshan – Co-existentialism*, Part 1: *Holistic View of Human Behaviour*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: all units in Omnipresence (p. 11); evidence chain and "Believe what is known" (p. 12); deluded and awakened action (*Verity*, p. 14); "Only awakened humans" (p. 33); Space as knowledge and *gyan-vivek-vigyan* (pp. 35, 143, 155); threefold truth (p. 37); *medhas* and activities of *jeevan* (p. 83); *darshan-drishya-drishti* (p. 84); *sanskar* definition (p. 90); knowledge unfolding by awakened humans (p. 115); "Realisation in coexistence" (p.

116); false learning definition (p. 184); brain and cognitive-organ signal pathway (p. 200); mystery and certitude (p. 209); doubt and mis-evaluation (pp. 263–264); Ch. 17 *Rahasy-mukti* — mystery, intellectual mystery, paths, four supports, and liberation as bliss (pp. 273–301); knowledge unfolding through *jeevan*/thoughts (p. 289); awakening–*sanskar* cycle (p. 290); "Realisation in knowledge" (p. 316); "delusion-less knowledge" (p. 317); "Brahma is truth, the world is perpetual" ("Fundamental Concepts," point 8, p. 13).

- **KD** — Nagraj, A. *Manav Karm Darshan* (Madhyasth Darshan, Part 2). Working English translation; Hindi–English review edition. Cited by paraphrase: autobiographical *Alternative* (points 1, 5, and 11); fundamental concepts; action, desire, and result (Ch. 1); physical, intellectual, and coexistential knowledge (pp. 3–4); direct perception, inference, and testimony-activity (pp. 20–21); projection–reflection (§§3.12, 3.16–3.17); human joint form (§3.16); knowledge–knower–known (§3.17); seer–doer–enjoyer (§3.18). The English text is a working translation; quoted formulations should be checked against the Hindi.
- **SB** — Nagraj, A. *Samadhanatmak Bhautikvad (Resolution Centred Materialism)*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: Balance of cognisance and sensitivity (p. 64); Threefold knowledge (p. 116); *satta* naming (p. 48); conservation (p. 49); realisation in coexistence (p. 51); evidence through experimentation, behaviour, and experience (p. 44); Human as seer (p. 188); Seer-status in existence (p. 239).
- **JV** — Nagraj, A. *Jeevan Vidya: An Introduction*. English translation by Rakesh Gupta. Cited: Proof by conveying understanding (p. 26); human body provisioned to evidence understanding (p. 59); birth, death, and *jeevan* continuity (p. 20); values and evaluation not bodily processes (p. 39); four-and-a-half activities in delusion (p. 73); *jeevan* evaluates without external instrument (p. 139); ten activities of *jeevan* (p. 92); root of delusion and belief-vs-knowledge (p. 93); definition of knowledge (p. 165); purview of sensitivity (p. 166).

Advaita Vedanta (primary texts)

- **BG** — *Bhagavad Gita*. Cited: field and knower of the field (13.1–13.3); prescribed action (3.8); *loka-sangraha* and action by the enlightened (3.20, 3.25–26).
- **BU** — *Brihadaranyaka Upanishad*. Cited: *neti neti* (2.3.6); *shravana–manana–nididhyasana* (2.4.5).
- **DDV** — *Drig-Drishya-Viveka* (traditionally attributed to Shankara or Bharati Tirtha; authorship disputed). Cited: seer and seen discrimination (p. 15).
- **BSB** — Shankara, Adi. *Brahma Sutra Bhashya*. Cited: the *Adhyasa Bhashya* (preamble) on superimposition of self and not-self; Brahman as source of the universe (1.1.2); Upanishadic knowledge and removal of ignorance.
- **CU** — *Chandogya Upanishad*. Cited: clay analogy (6.1.4); "one only, without a second" (6.2.1); *tat tvam asi* (6.8.7).

- **MU** — *Mandukya Upanishad*. Cited: three states and *turiya* (vv. 3–7).
- **TU** — *Taittiriya Upanishad*. Cited: Brahman as Truth, Knowledge, and Infinity (2.1.1); five sheaths (2.1–2.5).
- **VC** — *Vivekachudamani* (traditionally attributed to Shankara; authorship disputed). Cited as a later pedagogical witness: qualification (vv. 17–20); five sheaths (vv. 154–212); Existence-Knowledge-Bliss (v. 152); Maya, Ishvara, and *jiva* (vv. 243–244); *jiva* as Brahman (v. 216); Brahman as one's own Self (v. 393); liberation without seeker or bound soul (v. 574).
- **VP** — Dharmaraja Adhvarindra. *Vedanta Paribhasa*. Later systematic manual cited for the sixfold *pramana* account and empirical cognition (§2.6).

Related studies in this collection

- The Ontology of Coexistence — Omnipresence and saturation (§§1.1–1.2), *jeevan* faculties and projection–reflection (§1.7), realisation and the knowledge–knower–known relation (§1.13), Sat-Chit-Ananda contrast (§5.6), and open evidence problems (§6.2).
- Coexistence From First Principles — interpretive reconstruction of the knowledge-order cycle, karma and conduct-evidence, and non-substitutable human goals (§§4.13–4.15); used conceptually here without its notation.
- Human Behavior and Society — manifest, effable knowledge versus mystery-based ineffability (§3).
- *Spiritual-Practice-And-Realization* (Ongoing) — *dhyan*, yoga, six flaws, and the detailed practice path related to §1.8.

Modern Western philosophy and science

- **Chalmers 1995** — Chalmers, D. "Facing Up to the Problem of Consciousness." *Journal of Consciousness Studies*, 2(3), 200–219. Cited: hard problem of experience (§3.4).
- **Churchland 1986** — Churchland, P. S. *Neurophilosophy: Toward a Unified Science of the Mind-Brain*. MIT Press.
- **Dennett 1991** — Dennett, D. *Consciousness Explained*. Little, Brown.
- **Frankish 2016** — Frankish, K. "Illusionism as a Theory of Consciousness." *Journal of Consciousness Studies*, 23(11–12), 11–39.
- **Fricker 2007** — Fricker, M. *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. Oxford University Press. Cited: testimonial and social conditions of knowing (§3.1).
- **Gettier 1963** — Gettier, E. L. "Is Justified True Belief Knowledge?" *Analysis*, 23(6), 121–123.
- **Goldman 1979** — Goldman, A. I. "What Is Justified Belief?" In G. Pappas (ed.), *Justification and Knowledge*, 1–23. Cited: process reliabilism (§3.1).

- **Goff 2019** — Goff, P. *Galileo's Error: Foundations for a New Science of Consciousness*. Pantheon.
- **Hashemi 2025** — Hashemi, A. "How to Understand Russellian Panpsychism." *Erkenntnis*, 90, 3747–3766. Author preprint; also at https://doi.org/10.1007/s10670-024-00877-6.
- **IEP Enactivism** — "Enactivism." *Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy*.
- **Jarczewski and Riggs 2025** — Jarczewski, D., and Riggs, W. D. "Socializing Virtue Epistemology." *Episteme*, First View, 1–19.
- **Kandel et al. 2021** — Kandel, E. R., et al. *Principles of Neural Science*, 6th ed. McGraw-Hill.
- **Kim 2005** — Kim, J. *Physicalism, or Something Near Enough*. Princeton University Press.
- **Kuhn 2024** — Kuhn, R. L. "A Landscape of Consciousness: Toward a Taxonomy of Explanations and Implications." *Progress in Biophysics and Molecular Biology*, 190, 28–169.
- **Limanowski and Blankenburg 2013** — Limanowski, J., and Blankenburg, F. "Minimal self-models and the free energy principle." *Frontiers in Human Neuroscience*, 7. https://doi.org/10.3389/fnhum.2013.00547
- **Massimi 2022** — Massimi, M. *Perspectival Realism.* Oxford University Press. Cited: science as view from somewhere (§3.7).
- **Melloni et al. 2025** — Melloni, L., et al. "Adversarial testing of global neuronal workspace and integrated information theories of consciousness." *Nature*. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41586-025-08888-1. Cited: IIT vs GNWT adversarial test (§4.3).
- **Nagel 1974** — Nagel, T. "What Is It Like to Be a Bat?" *The Philosophical Review*, 83(4), 435–450. Cited: first-person experience as datum (§3.4).
- **Parfit 1984** — Parfit, D. *Reasons and Persons*. Oxford University Press. Cited: personal identity reductionism (§3.6).
- **Piredda 2024** — Piredda, G. "The Tacitly Situated Self: From Narration to Sedimentation and Projection." *Topoi*, 43, 607–615.
- **Popper 1959** — Popper, K. *The Logic of Scientific Discovery*. Hutchinson / Routledge. Cited: hypothesis-testing and public criticism (§4.1).
- **SEP Personal Identity** — Olson, E. "Personal Identity." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: Locke, Parfit, and substance views (§3.6).
- **SEP Phenomenology** — Smith, D. W. "Phenomenology." *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy*. Cited: Husserl, intentionality, and embodied phenomenology (§3.7).
- **Sosa 2007** — Sosa, E. *A Virtue Epistemology: Apt Belief and Reflective Knowledge, Volume I*. Oxford University Press. Cited: knowledge as attributable intellectual success (§3.1).

- **Strawson 2006** — Strawson, G. "Realistic Monism: Why Physicalism Entails Panpsychism." *Journal of Consciousness Studies*, 13(10–11), 3–31. Cited: Russellian monism and panpsychism (§3.4).
- **Tufft et al. 2024** — Tufft, M. R. A., et al. "Forgetting ourselves in flow: an active inference account of flow states and how we experience ourselves within them." *Frontiers in Psychology*, 15. https://doi.org/10.3389/fpsyg.2024.1354719
- **Wiese 2024** — Wiese, W. "Artificial consciousness: a perspective from the free energy principle." *Philosophical Studies*, 181, 1947–1970.